Why Eating Well Feels Like Nothing:

Redesigning the Feedback Loop for Dietary Behaviour

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IRP Proposal | April 2026 | Final Submission

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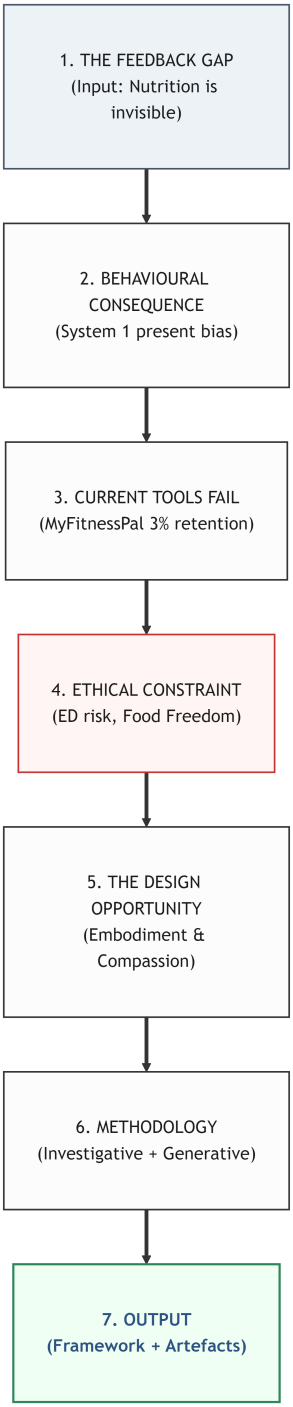
Executive Summary

This proposal investigates a persistent design problem in preventive health: **eating well produces weak, delayed, and emotionally flat feedback**, so intentions rarely become sustained behaviour. By contrast, exercise and sleep are reinforced by immediate, legible signals through tracking products and social rituals. The project asks what alternative dietary feedback paradigms could make nutrition more **legible**, **low-friction**, and **non-punitive** ("reflect, not judge") without increasing anxiety or reinforcing disordered eating.

Using a design futures approach, the research combines (1) literature and practice review, (2) qualitative interviews and autoethnographic diary work, and (3) speculative prototyping and scenario building towards 2035. The research contribution will be a **clear vocabulary and evaluation frame** for dietary feedback (legibility, effort, and affective tone), alongside a **set of design principles/patterns** for *non-punitive feedback* ("reflect, not judge"). Outputs will include (a) a multi-dimensional dietary wellbeing framework (a set of human-centred dimensions for describing dietary experience beyond calories) and (b) 3–5 speculative artefacts used as **research probes** to test feedback formats, assessed against explicit criteria for **Food Freedom** and risk of anxiety/disordered eating reinforcement.

Strategic Logic Chain

The deductive narrative path of the IRP research from feedback gap to speculative intervention.



Strategic Logic Chain

Statement of Authorship and Acknowledgements

This proposal was written independently as part of the IRP Proposal module, Global Innovation Design, Royal College of Art. The research direction emerged from an ongoing inquiry into preventive health, dietary behaviour, and the design of feedback systems, which began in my prior study at the University of Nottingham (IRP: The Small Revolution in Lifestyle Habits, 2024–2025).

I am grateful to my tutors for their feedback during the April 2026 project discussion, which helped sharpen the focus of this proposal — particularly in identifying the ethical dimension of eating disorders and food freedom as essential constraints on any proposed feedback design.

Use of AI Disclosure

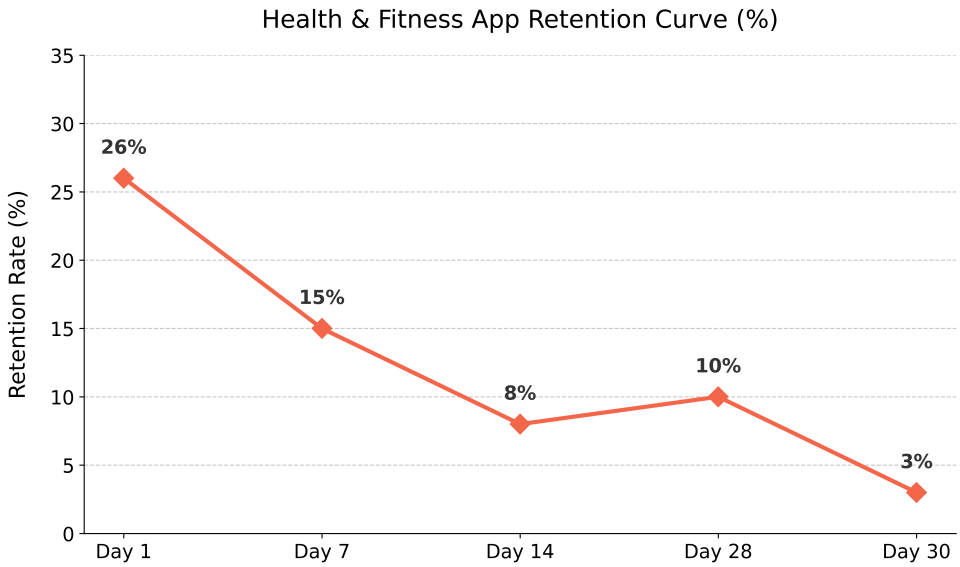
This submission was produced by me in my own words and using my own imagery, except for quotations and images from published and unpublished sources which are clearly indicated and acknowledged as such. I used AI assistance for: (1) systematic literature identification to locate relevant behavioral science papers; (2) technical document formatting and data visualization rendering. All critical analysis, theoretical framing, and speculative design directions are my original work.

Print name: Weijie Li Signed: _____ Date: April 12, 2026

1 Introduction and Justification of the Topic

I am interested in the future of preventive health behaviour and, in particular, the future of **dietary feedback design** for people who want to eat better but cannot reliably feel whether they are doing so. Unlike exercise or sleep, the benefits of nutrition are often delayed and difficult to perceive at the level of lived experience: days or weeks of eating well may produce no clear signal of progress. This is not only a motivation problem; it is a **feedback problem**.

Tracking products have made exercise and sleep legible by translating invisible physiology into immediate, **legible** cues (Norman, 2013). Dietary tools have lagged behind: the dominant paradigm still relies on high-friction manual logging, which many users discontinue quickly (Schembre et al., 2018). The Fogg Behaviour Model helps explain this failure: sustained behaviour requires sufficient Ability and well-timed Prompts, which manual logging systems often undermine (Fogg, 2009).



Evidence: Health & Fitness App Retention Curve (%)

This project investigates how alternative feedback paradigms might reduce the Intention–Action Gap in dietary behaviour by making nutrition more **legible**, **low-friction**, and **non-punitive** ("reflect, not judge"). The empirical focus is on everyday eating decisions in **micro environments** (e.g., home kitchens and routine meals), and the ethical constraint is explicit: any feedback system must preserve food joy, minimise anxiety, and avoid reinforcing disordered eating, supporting genuine **Food Freedom** (Tribole and Resch, 2020).

A design futures approach is appropriate because the project is not an engineering effort to invent new sensors; rather, it uses existing signals and trajectories (e.g., CGM as a cultural/technical signal) to prototype and evaluate **interaction patterns and feedback formats** that could shape preferable futures for dietary feedback (Dunne and Raby, 2013).

2 Background: Literature, Practice, Signals and Trends

2a. Research Questions

1. **Technical penetration (scope: everyday meals):** How might micro-scale, non-invasive sensing reduce reliance on manual food logging and make internal dietary processing more **legible** for non-specialists in daily life?

2. **Choice architecture (scope: micro environments):** How might the eating environment (kitchen/table/rituals) be redesigned to provide **low-friction** prompts and **non-punitive** feedback that supports healthier decisions?

3. **Ethical balance (evaluation):** What feedback formats and interaction patterns can support **non-punitive reflection** ("reflect, not judge"), minimise anxiety, and avoid reinforcing disordered eating tendencies, while protecting **Food Freedom**?

2b. Research Process

Research was conducted across three phases. The first phase involved a systematic literature review drawing on Google Scholar, PubMed, and design databases. The second phase was a practice review covering existing apps, wearables, and critical design projects. The third phase involved mapping signals and trends using the four-lens framework (Human / Society / Technology / Nature) introduced in the RCA Project Design Approach workshop (March 2026).

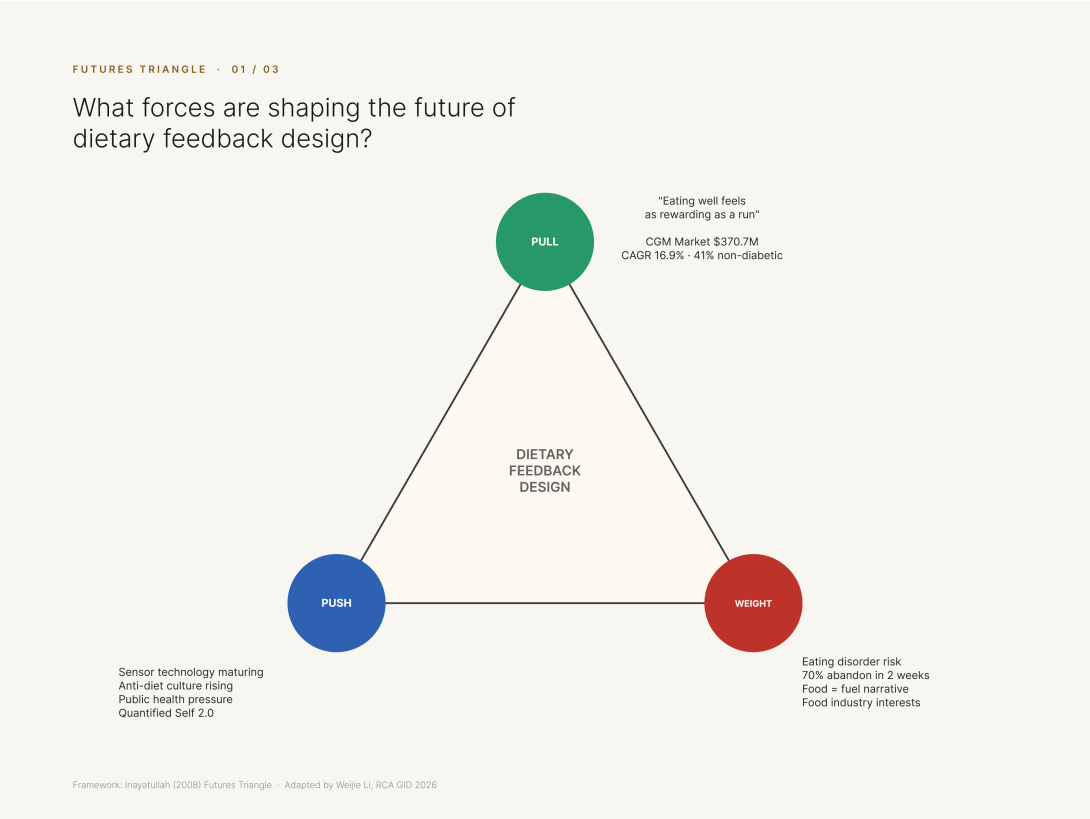


Figure 1: *Futures Triangle Analysis: Mapping the forces shaping dietary feedback.*

2c. Research Summary

The Feedback Gap: Why Eating Well Feels Like Nothing

The core problem is defined by a "phenomenological silence." When you eat a nutritious meal, you feel full, but the metabolic benefits—reduced inflammation, improved insulin sensitivity—play out over weeks at a cellular level imperceptible to the user. This gap triggers **hyperbolic discounting** (Kahneman, 2011), where System 1 fast-thinking prioritizes immediate sensory reward over abstract long-term health.

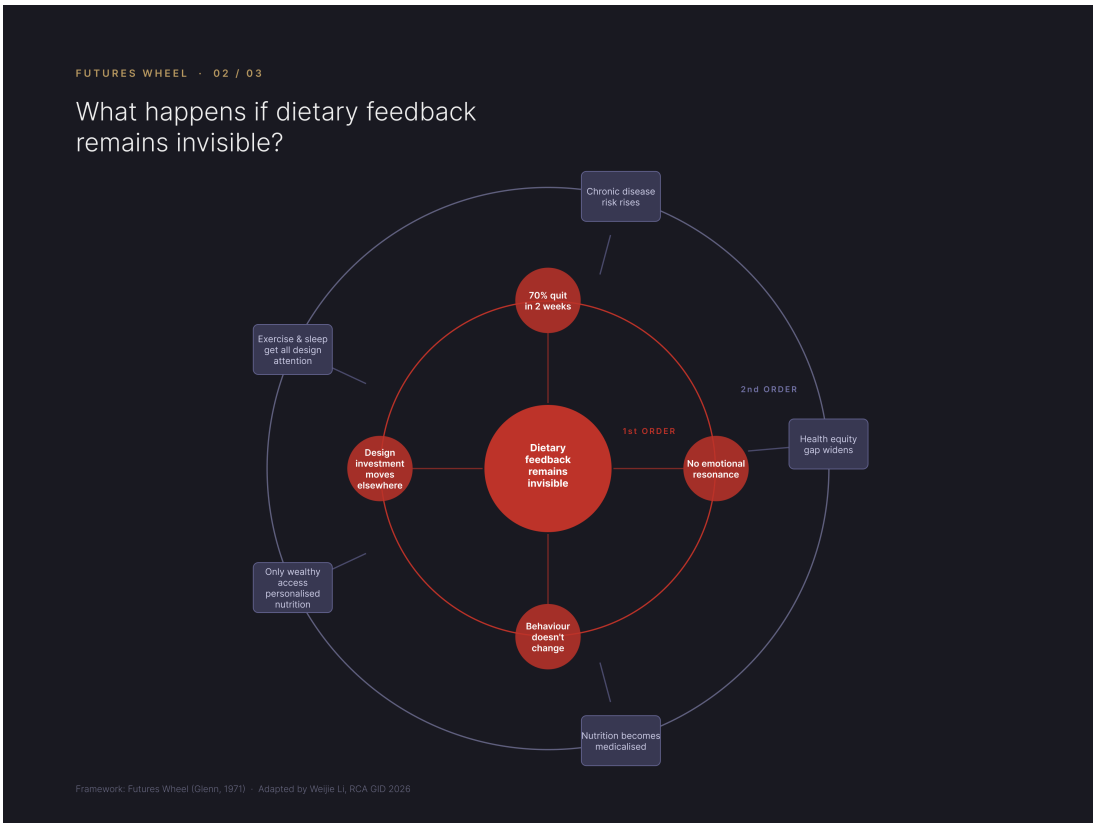
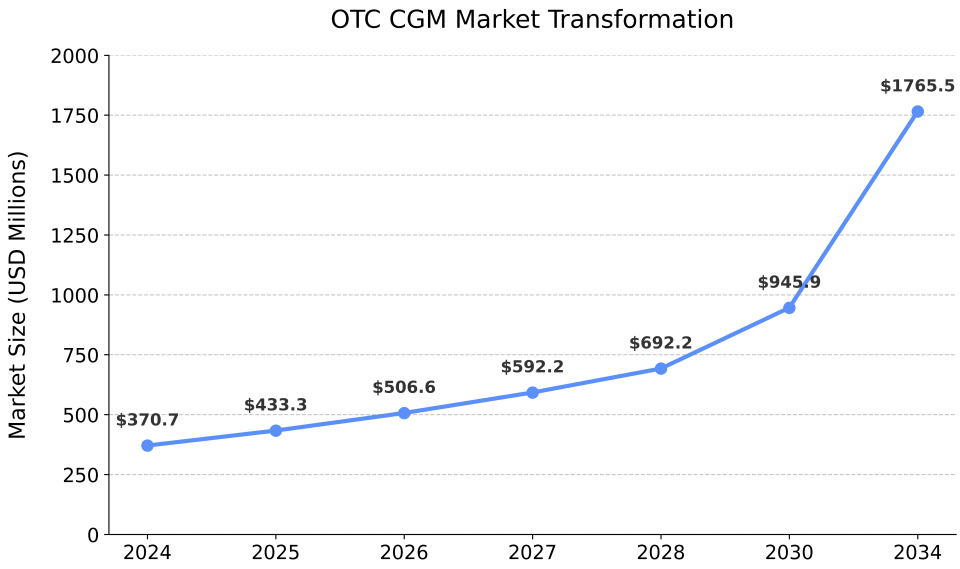


Figure 2: *Futures Wheel: Consequences of the persistent feedback gap.*

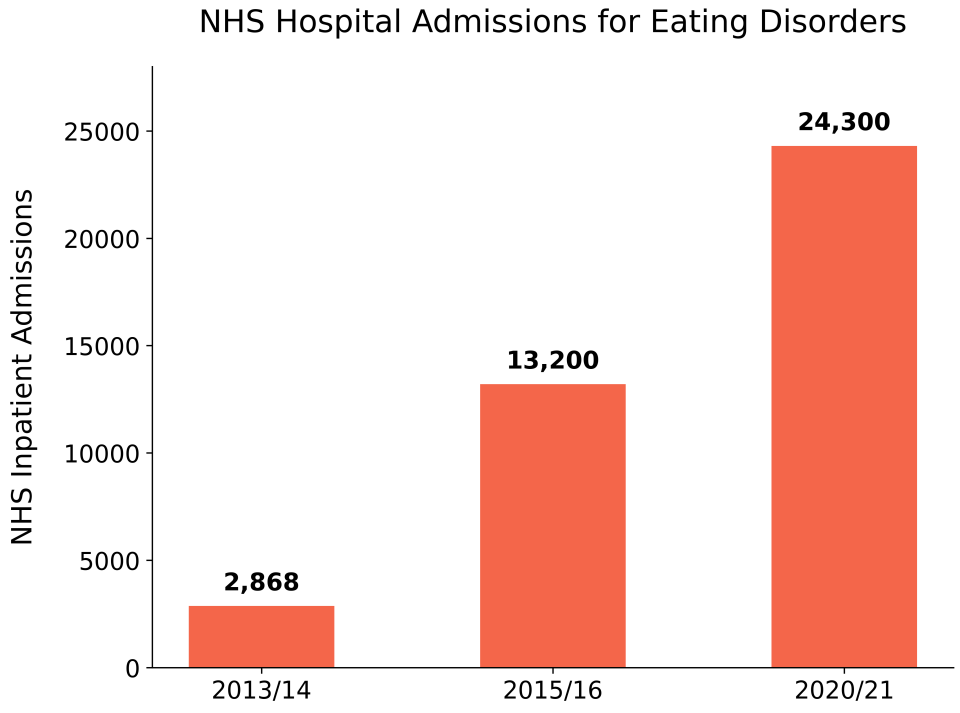
The emergence of **Continuous Glucose Monitoring (CGM)** for non-diabetics represents a key signal of where dietary feedback could go, yet it also highlights the risks of invasive surveillance and data-induced anxiety. In this proposal, CGM is treated primarily as a **design signal** informing feedback imagination and critique, rather than as a technology to be engineered or clinically validated.



Evidence: CGM Market Transformation

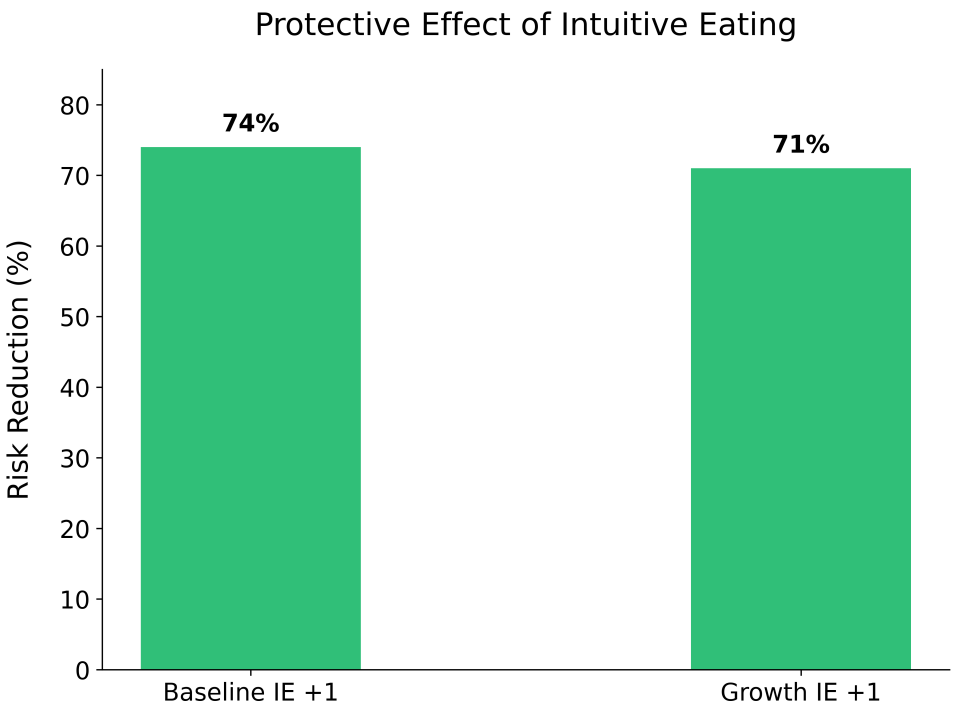
The Eating Disorder Constraint

Tutorial feedback in April 2026 highlighted that feedback design carries acute ethical risk. Roth et al. (2024) established significant associations between intensive dietary tracking and elevated disordered eating risk.



Evidence: UK Clinical Trends

The **Intuitive Eating** movement offers a protective counter-framework by cultivating internal body attunement rather than external rules.



Evidence: Protective Effect of Intuitive Eating

🔑 Key Principles & Design Implications

Intuitive Eating Principle	Design Constraint for This Project
Reject the Diet Mentality	No weight-loss framing in feedback
Honour Your Hunger	System must not override internal hunger signals
Make Peace with Food	No "good food / bad food" binary in any feedback
Challenge the Food Police	Eliminate guilt-inducing notifications or scoring
Discover the Satisfaction Factor	Feedback should reinforce pleasure, not diminish it
Feel Your Fullness	Design should amplify, not replace, body attunement
Cope with Your Emotions without Using Food	System must not weaponise emotional states
Respect Your Body	No body-shaming metrics or comparisons
Movement — Feel the Difference	Feedback should feel good, not punitive
Honour Your Health with Gentle Nutrition	Nutrition guidance, not nutrition surveillance

Overall Assessment	Detail
Strength	Empirically supported; defines what "harm-free" design looks like
Limitation	Primarily a clinical/therapeutic framework — needs translation to product design

Figure 3: *Intuitive Eating Principles as Design Constraints.*

Reframing through Tutor Feedback (April 8)

Tutorials introduced three critical frameworks: **Compassion-Based Design**, **Embodiment vs. Empowerment**, and **Cultural Case Studies** (Japanese Itadakimasu, French food rituals, Karl Krukow).

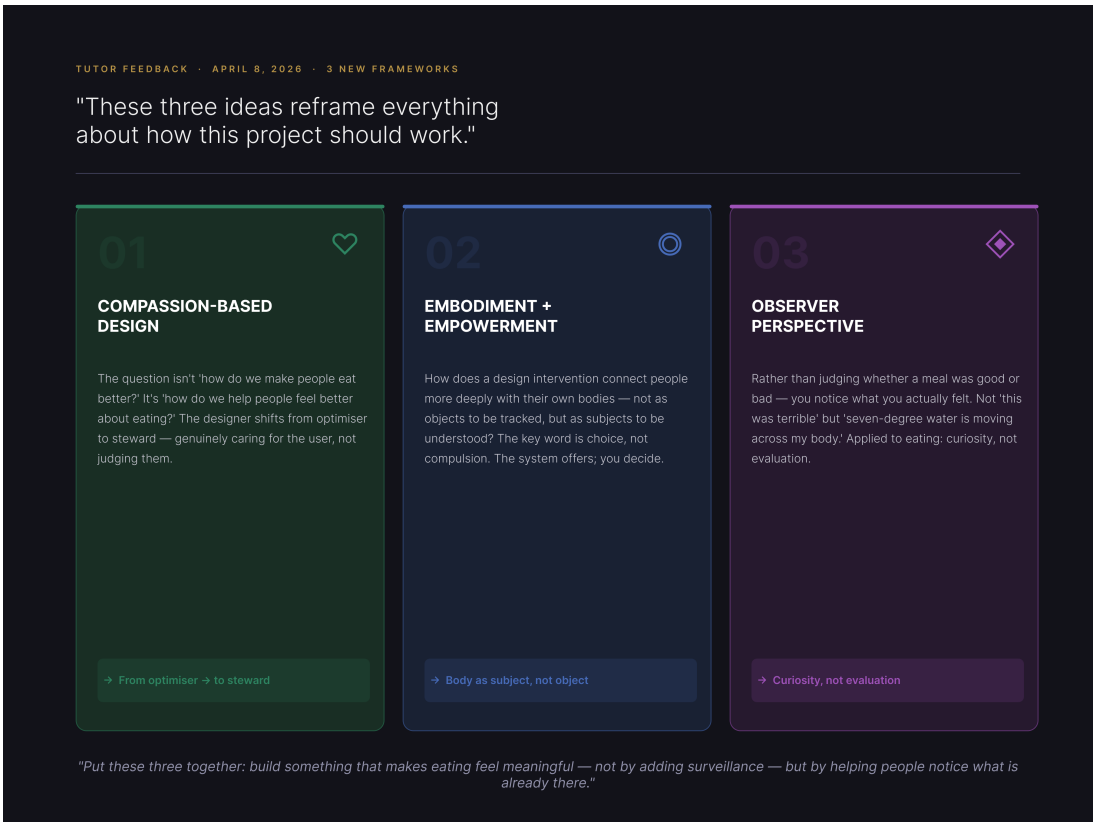


Figure 4: *Tutor Feedback Sketch Model — Reframing the project logic.*

3 Problem Framing

The Challenge: The Intention–Action Gap

The central challenge this project engages is the *Intention–Action Gap in dietary behaviour*: people often hold sincere intentions to eat better, yet struggle to sustain those behaviours. The gap is not simply a lack of knowledge or motivation; it is a **feedback problem**. In everyday experience, dietary change is characterised by **phenomenological silence**: meaningful metabolic processes unfold at a micro scale, while the surface of lived experience offers weak, delayed, and emotionally flat signals. Without **legible, non-punitive** feedback, behaviour cannot be reinforced or iterated — and many people abandon dietary tools that rely on high-friction manual logging.

Reframing: Data-Assisted Intuition (Non-punitive Feedback)

This IRP does not treat dietary change as a choice between "intuition" and "data". Instead, it explores how **micro-scale, non-invasive data** can be combined with **behaviour and environment design** to **support and re-awaken intuitive food perception**. The design goal is not to *judge* eating, but to enable **non-punitive reflection** ("reflect, not judge") through feedback that is **legible**, low-friction, and ethically safe — preserving **Food Freedom** while reducing the risk of anxiety and disordered eating reinforcement.

System-Level Perspectives

This project operates primarily at the intersection of two systemic lenses:

- **Human:** Individual dietary behaviour, cognitive biases (hyperbolic discounting, present bias), emotional relationships with food, body image, and lived eating experience. This is the primary lens.
- **Technology:** Existing feedback tools, sensor technology (CGM, wearables), data visualisation, AI food recognition, and the design infrastructure of behaviour change applications. This is the secondary lens.
- **Society (contextual):** Diet culture, eating disorder prevalence, the anti-diet movement, food advertising, and public health frameworks. This provides critical context and ethical constraints.
- **Nature (contextual):** Gut microbiome, metabolic biology, circadian eating patterns, and the physiological reality of nutrition. This grounds the project in biological reality.

Temporal and Contextual Scale

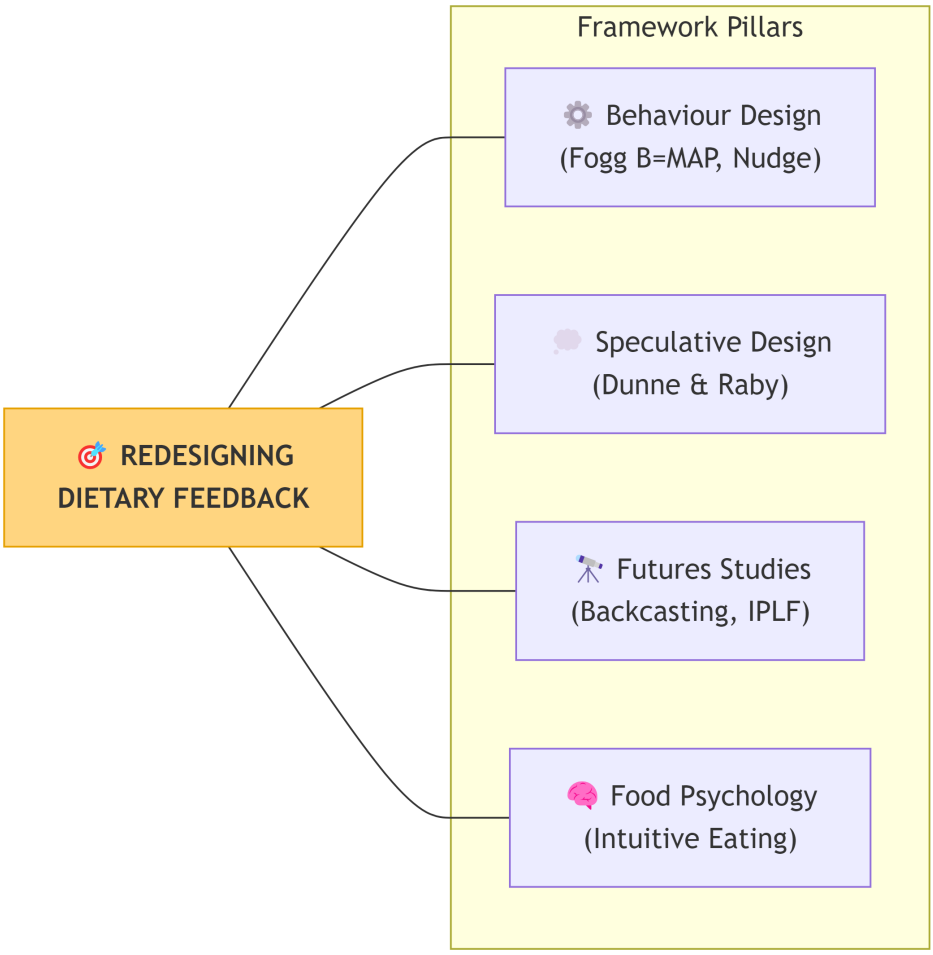
- **Temporal:** The project operates at a medium-to-long term temporal scale: **5–20 years**. This is appropriate because: (1) preventive health interventions require years to demonstrate measurable outcomes; (2) the sensor technology needed for non-invasive dietary feedback is 5–10 years from consumer readiness; and (3) the cultural shift from diet-culture to food freedom thinking is still unfolding. The speculative design work will project forward to 2035, using backcasting from a preferred future to identify present-day intervention points (Martell, 2026).
- **Contextual:** The primary scale is **micro** — the individual's daily experience of eating, at the level of a single meal, a kitchen, a phone screen. This is where the feedback gap is most acutely felt and where design can most directly intervene. The project will also engage **meso** scale considerations (how design products shape cultural norms around eating)

and acknowledge **macro** drivers (public health systems, food industry incentives) as the systemic context within which any intervention must operate.

4 Design Futures Approach

Disciplinary Positioning

This project is situated at the intersection of two primary disciplinary fields: *Behaviour Design* (the design of systems that support deliberate human behaviour change) and *Speculative / Critical Design* (the use of design fiction and provocative artefacts to interrogate assumptions about technology and futures). It draws on Futures Studies for its temporal orientation, and on Food Studies and Health Psychology for its empirical grounding.



The Three Roles of the Design Futurist

As a design futurist on this project, my role is threefold:

1. **Cartographer of the Present**: Mapping why the current dietary feedback landscape looks the way it does — what assumptions it encodes, what it optimises for, and whose interests it serves.

2. **Critical Provocateur**: Designing speculative artefacts that make visible the absences and contradictions in current food technology, and that open space for imagining radically different futures.

3. **Preferential Futurist**: Using backcasting methodology (working backwards from a preferred future in which eating well is **legible**, **low-friction**, and **non-punitive**) to identify near-term design opportunities and interventions (Martell, 2026).

Design Approaches

- **Behavioural Architecture:** The work uses behaviour design (Fogg's B=MAP) and choice-architecture thinking (Thaler and Sunstein) to locate where Ability and Prompts break down in everyday eating, and to prototype lower-friction alternatives.
- **Non-punitive feedback (compassion, embodiment, agency):** A single guiding constraint shapes all concepts: feedback should support embodied attunement and user agency through *descriptive reflection* rather than moralising scores. This principle informs the interview prompts, the coding of qualitative themes (e.g., shame, control, relief, joy), and the evaluation rubric (Section 5f).

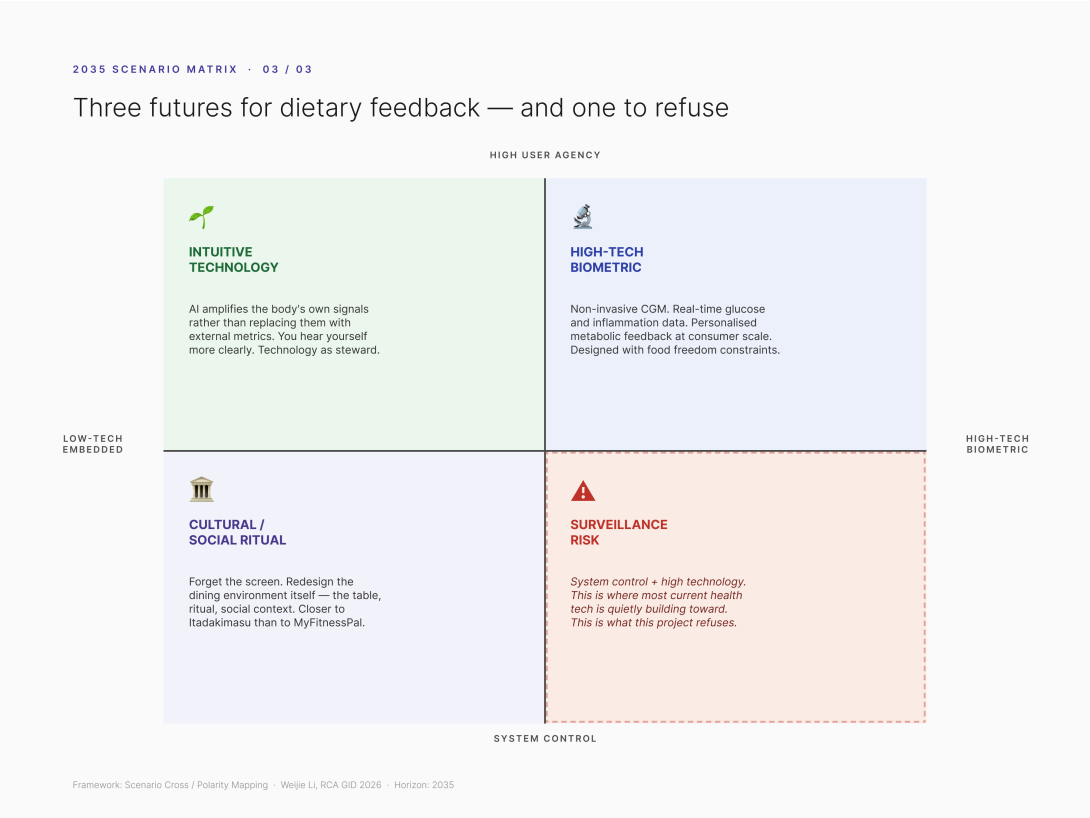
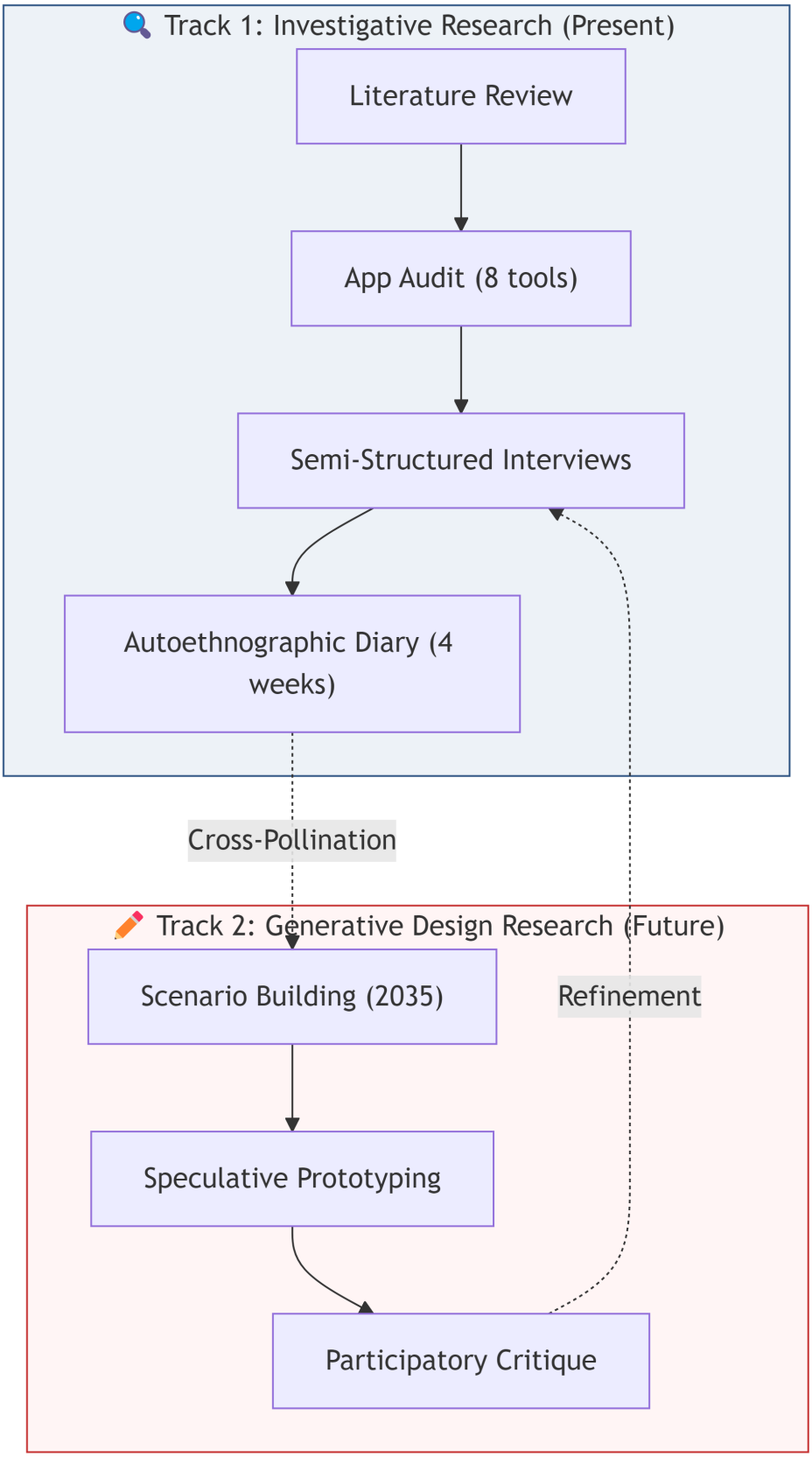


Figure 5: *2035 Scenario Matrix: User Agency vs. Technology Type.*

5 Methodology

The methodology operates on two parallel and mutually informing tracks: investigative research (understanding the current landscape and its failures) and generative design research (developing and testing alternative feedback paradigms). This dual-track structure reflects the nature of the problem: the failure of dietary feedback is simultaneously an empirical, behavioural, and design question, and no single disciplinary method is sufficient to address it.

Dual-Track Methodology Overview



5a. Data: Types, Sources and Participants

- **Data types:** Primary qualitative data will be generated through semi-structured interviews and an autoethnographic diary study. Secondary qualitative data will be drawn from the literature review and app audit. Secondary quantitative data will be drawn from published studies on app adoption rates, disordered eating prevalence, and behaviour change outcomes.

- **Data sources:** Academic databases (Google Scholar, PubMed), design archives and app stores, peer-reviewed journals in behavioural science and health psychology, and primary research participants.

- **Participants:** For the semi-structured interview phase, 6–8 participants will be recruited. **Inclusion criteria:** adults aged 22–45; current or prior use of at least one dietary tracking or food logging tool; willingness to discuss emotional relationship with food. **Exclusion criteria:** current diagnosis of an eating disorder (to protect participant wellbeing and avoid harm). Recruitment will be conducted through the RCA student community and personal networks. This sample size is appropriate for qualitative thematic analysis, following Braun and Clarke's (2006) guidance that 6–10 participants typically suffice to reach thematic saturation in homogeneous purposive samples.

5b. Data Collection Methods

- **Phase 0 — Informal Peer Conversations (exploratory, pre-interview):** Before conducting formal interviews, an initial exploratory phase will involve informal conversations with peers in the RCA GID programme. These conversations will focus on a simple, open question: *what is your current relationship with health tracking and your body?* This phase serves to identify recurring themes and blind spots before designing the interview protocol, and to practise the researcher's role as an engaged listener on this topic.

- **Semi-structured interviews (6–8 participants, 45–60 minutes each):** Interviews will explore participants' lived experience of dietary tracking: what prompted them to use it, how it made them feel, what worked and what failed, and how it affected their relationship with food. The semi-structured format allows flexibility while ensuring consistency across participants.

- **Autoethnographic diary study (4 weeks, self-conducted):** A structured self-observation practice focused on everyday meals. Each entry will record: (1) context (where/with whom/time pressure), (2) trigger/prompt, (3) friction/Ability barriers, (4) perceived feedback (if any), (5) affective tone (e.g., calm, guilt, pride, anxiety), and (6) a short design note ("what could the environment/interface reflect here?"). The diary will adopt an *observer perspective* drawn from mindful eating traditions, using descriptive language rather than moral categories ("good/bad" foods). Diary synthesis will translate recurring patterns into design principles and prototype prompts for later critique.

- **App audit and comparative analysis:** A systematic evaluation of 8 dietary feedback tools (MyFitnessPal, Noom, Levels Health, Signos, Nutrisense, FoodVisor, NHS Weight Loss Plan) assessing immediacy of feedback, emotional tenor, legibility for non-specialists, social dimension, and eating disorder risk indicators.

5c. Data Analysis Methods

Interview data will be analysed using *reflexive thematic analysis* (Braun and Clarke, 2006), a method appropriate for identifying patterns of meaning across qualitative data without imposing

predetermined categories. Themes will be developed inductively from the data, then reviewed against the theoretical framework (Fogg's B=MAP, intuitive eating principles) to develop design implications. Diary data will be analysed through *design-led synthesis*: converting observational notes and sketches directly into design provocations, using the 'what if' question as an analytical tool.

5d. Design and Futures Methods

- **Speculative Prototyping (Dunne and Raby, 2013):** Drawing on critical design methodology, a series of three to five speculative artefacts will be developed that propose radically different dietary feedback mechanisms: for example, an ambient object that changes texture in response to nutritional balance; a social ritual tool that makes eating well a shared, celebratory experience; or a wearable that provides physiological biofeedback from the gut. These are provocations — design fictions that defamiliarise current assumptions and make alternative futures imaginable.

- **Scenario Building:** Three scenarios for dietary feedback in 2035 will be developed: (1) the High-Tech Biometric scenario; (2) the Ambient Social scenario; and (3) the Intuitive Technology scenario, in which AI works to amplify internal body attunement rather than replace it. Scenarios will be built using the Intelligence–Perspective–Logic–Foresight framework (Martell, 2026).

- **Participatory critique:** Speculative artefacts and scenarios will be shared with interview participants for a second round of engagement, following participatory design principles. This closes the loop between investigation and generation, and ensures the speculative work remains grounded in real user experience.

5e. Methodological Justification

This methodology is appropriate because the problem — the absence of meaningful dietary feedback — is fundamentally an experiential and cultural problem, not merely a technical one. The choice to eat, and the feelings it generates, are shaped by biology, memory, identity, social context, and centuries of cultural meaning. Qualitative and speculative methods are therefore better suited than quantitative approaches to uncovering the phenomenology of eating and to imagining feedback systems that can operate within this complexity.

5f. Evaluation Criteria and Ethical Safeguards

All emerging concepts, scenarios, and speculative artefacts will be assessed against a consistent set of criteria derived from the project framing (legibility, low friction, and **non-punitive reflection**) and the ethical constraint of **Food Freedom**. In participatory critique sessions, participants will be asked to (1) interpret what a concept is communicating in their own words, (2) describe how it would change a real meal decision, and (3) reflect on emotional impact and likelihood of compulsive checking; responses will be captured through short prompts and researcher notes alongside a lightweight rubric. The evaluation rubric will include:

- **Legibility:** can a non-specialist interpret what the feedback is communicating (and what it is *not* claiming)?

- **Friction / Ability:** what effort is required from the user (time, cognitive load, manual logging), and where does drop-off occur?

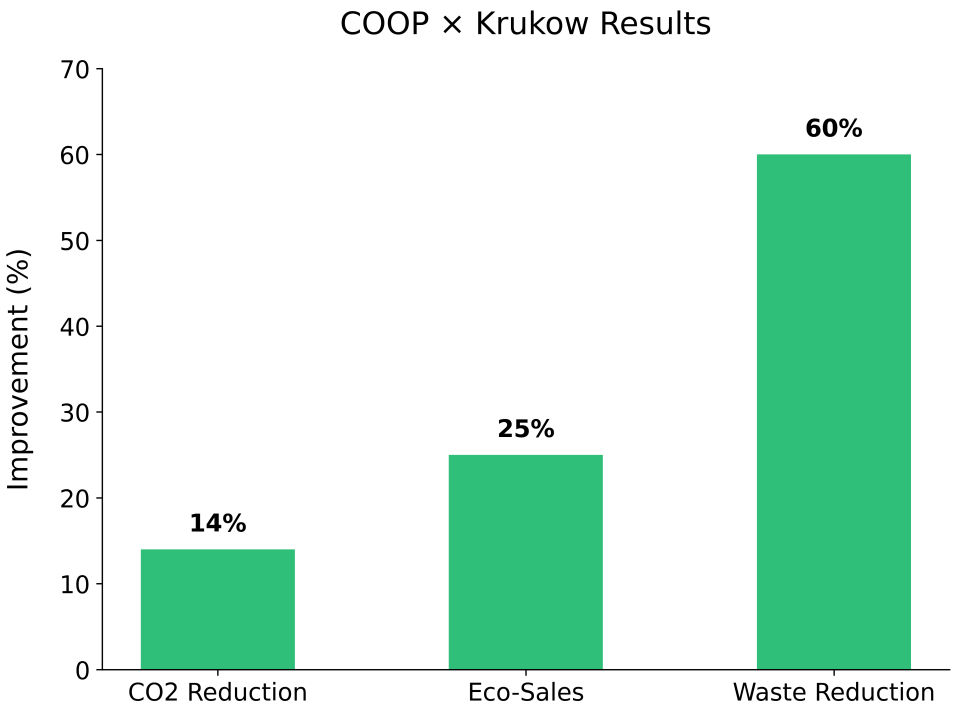
- **Affective tone:** does the feedback feel like *reflection* (curious, descriptive) or *judgement* (scoring, moralising, shaming)?

- **Anxiety / compulsion risk signals:** does the concept encourage obsessive checking, numerical fixation, or guilt-based compliance?
- **Food Freedom:** does the concept preserve agency, flexibility, and enjoyment of eating (including the option to disengage)?

Risk mitigation measures include: (1) exclusion of participants with a current eating-disorder diagnosis; (2) interview wording that avoids moral language ("good/bad" foods) and weight-loss targets; (3) participant debrief and opt-out at any point; and (4) treating "ethical safety" claims in this phase as **preliminary**, to be strengthened in later work through expert consultation and broader testing.

6 Critique Documentation

Summary (April 8 Tutorial): Direction confirmed as unique. Integrated **Compassion-Based Design** as the core philosophy. Tutor emphasized connecting people *more* with their bodies (Embodiment) while giving them agency (Empowerment). Recommended case studies: French paradox, Itadakimasu, and Krukow × COOP.



Evidence: COOP × Krukow Results

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7 Project Outputs, Stakeholders and Impacts

Planned Outputs

- **Research outputs:** A Multi-dimensional Dietary Wellbeing Framework (dimensions for describing dietary experience, feedback, and affect beyond calories) + literature/practice synthesis on "phenomenological silence" and dietary feedback.
- **Futures outputs:** Three 2035 scenarios (high-tech biometric / ambient-social / intuitive technology) used to structure critique, reveal trade-offs, and generate near-term design implications via backcasting.
- **Speculative design outputs:** 3–5 speculative artefacts used as **research probes** (not product claims) to test non-punitive feedback formats against the evaluation rubric (Section 5f).

Stakeholders and Intended Impact

- **Stakeholders:** health-tech designers; preventive health clinicians; public health researchers; food culture practitioners; and people with lived experience of tracking fatigue.

- **Impact:** shifting "nutrition tracking" from optimisation and surveillance towards **care, agency, and Food Freedom**, while developing concrete design principles for **non-punitive** feedback.

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8 Personal Objectives

To develop world-class expertise at the intersection of behavioural design and speculative futures, building a practice focused on **Ethical Health Innovation**.

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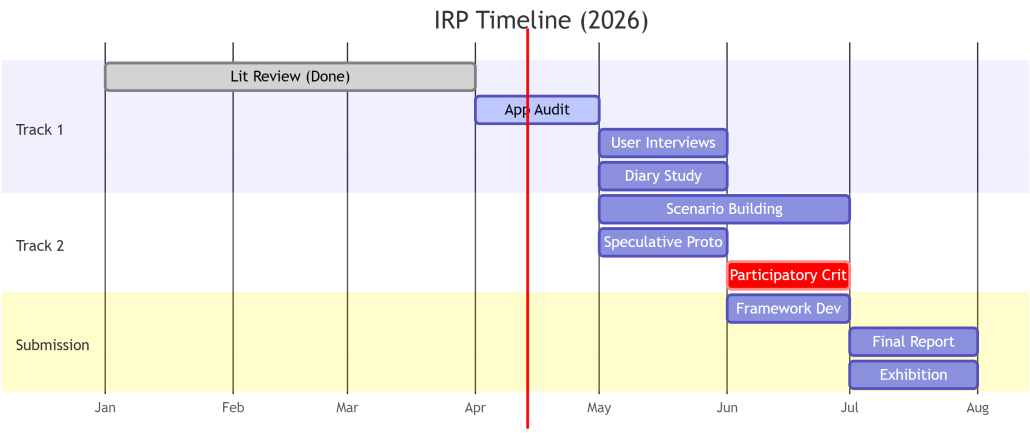
9 Project Plan



Reference List

All references formatted in Harvard style. Listed alphabetically by first author's surname or organisation.

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Appendices

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